survived before modern scholarship discovered him.[1] While a monograph is waiting to be written on the pastiche of stories and images around him, here I look only at elements in the remembrance of things Ashokan. I do this to highlight the fact that he was a sovereign around whom a long tradition of memorialization came to be consolidated, as also to assess in broad brushstrokes what was retained of his historical life and what forgotten.

It is necessary, first, to keep in mind that, even though a great deal is not known about them, the Maurya dynasty's kings continued to rule for several decades after Ashoka's death. While narratives of Ashoka's unhappy last days are entangled within legends, historical events in the lives of the emperor's successors are not even known by such; and the dearth of contemporary chronicles and accounts of the Ashoka years persists into those of his successors. No Mauryan ruler after Ashoka set down a substantial body of epigraphs on stone. None was visited by a chronicler-ambassador from a foreign land, as Chandragupta was by Megasthenes. Even when these years find mention in traditions that were put together several centuries later, elementary information, such as the names and number of kings in the succession line of the later Mauryas, remains in dispute.

Ashoka's successors do not figure in the Pali chronicles of Sri Lanka either. Those texts lose interest in the Maurya dynastic line after the emperor's death, presumably because by then his Buddhist progeny were firmly ensconced on the island. There are, moreover, discrepancies in the list of successors that figure in texts of the Northern Buddhist tradition and the Brahmanical *Puranas;* in the *Puranas* the succession details are not uniformly similar. Much of the literature on Ashoka's successors consists of hairsplitting disputes over royal names, regnal numbers, and precise orders of succession.

The Puranic litany of names of Mauryan rulers, depending on the text, mention anything between four and seven as the number to follow Ashoka,